four varna divisions based on ritual status and purity (the philosophers enjoy a higher status, but his schema doesn't convey a strong hierarchy). Scholars have puzzled over his characterization, attributing it to confusion on his part, an interpolation by Graeco-Roman authors to make it parallel to the seven social divisions in Egypt and a few other theories. After all, Megasthenes was also wrong in claiming that there was no slavery in India. Indian sources, including the *Arthashastra*, attest to its presence though it was different from the system of slavery prevalent in Greece, so Megasthenes likely didn't recognize it as such.[23]

Mauryan India was a strange society to Megasthenes and his fellow Greeks. He could only enter it so far. He must have faced linguistic hurdles too. Perhaps he befriended Seleucus's Greek daughter, a queen of Chandragupta, and gossiped in their mother tongue about Mauryan courtiers. One gets the sense from *Indica* that he also partook in the sensuous joys of travel and discovery. He marvels at all the strange land animals and birds of India: parrots that are taught to speak and become 'as talkative as children'; apes with hair on the forehead and 'luxuriant beards hanging down their breast'; the Indian hoopoe, 'the favourite plaything of the king of the Indians, who carries it on his hand, and toys with it, and never tires gazing in ecstasy on its splendour, and the beauty with which Nature has adorned it'. If only we knew what his Mauryan hosts thought of this interesting visitor from the west.